



Popular media's role in fostering sex education in middle schools: A comparative analysis of Netflix series *Sex Education* and Bollywood film *Oh My God 2*

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ABSTRACT

India as a country has always been seen as a repository of culture and heritage. The historical ruins, temples, scriptures of this ancient land foster liberty regarding sexuality and its significance in the advancement of civilization. However, sex education is still a taboo and an alien topic in the Indian education system. On the other hand, in the USA, one of the most advanced countries, sex education is a mandate, but sadly, there are middle schools in many states in the USA, which do not ponder over the subject at all. The reason behind this is the fact that there is no unified National Policy regarding Sex-Education in the USA, it is vested with the states individually. The USA government had been promoting 'Abstinence-only-until-marriage' (AOUM) education till Obama came. Even after implementing an evidence-based sex education system, the overall status of comprehensive sex education is unsatisfactory in the USA. This research aims at dealing with the issues associated with implementing and practising sex-education in the middle school and how the popular media deals with it and influences it. The paper takes into account the famous Netflix series *Sex Education* which is hugely applauded for its candid and inclusive approach towards sex and sexuality of teenagers and the recent Bollywood film *OMG2* which serves as a critique of the Indian education system which fails to provide proper knowledge on the subject and jeopardises the adolescent life.

1. Introduction

The topic of Sex-education in middle schools is a global concern and there has been much discussion over it since ages, educators and policymakers are in search of effective ways to address adolescent sexuality in a diverse cultural backdrop of India. The traditional cultural norms and conservative attitudes towards sex and sexuality plays a havoc role with regards to the decision of including sex education in the middle-school curriculum. The private schools of India are free to choose sex-education for their curriculum; in fact, those who are affiliated to the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) have the mandate to include components of sex education. But how many of them truly exercise this instruction depends heavily on the geographical location of that school. From 2006–2016, UNESCO operated a campaign called 'Udaan', a school-based adolescent education programme in Jharkhand which helped in spreading sexual awareness among 26 districts of Jharkhand. But India, being a country of millions of young people need a lot of expansive sex-education program. It is not only necessary for understanding the onset of changes in a adolescent body, but it has been

argued that comprehensive sex education in schools is necessary to address issues such as teenage pregnancy, sexually transmitted infections (STIs), sexual abuse, and gender-based violence, which are prevalent among adolescents in the country. As per Sharmita Kar's (2023) article titled 'A Culture Shock Called Sex Education',

In 2005, the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) issued a circular introducing a program called 'The Adolescence Reproductive and Sexual Health Education' (ASRH). The Union government released it in 2006 but it was not very successful. While some states incorporated the program, most adopted it with variations according to what they considered "important" or, rather, what they felt comfortable with. (Kar, 2023)

The perimeter of 'importance' and 'comfort' depend heavily on the authority of the concerned schools and its educators. Conservative societal norms, religious beliefs, and concerns about the appropriateness of discussing such topics with young adolescents contribute to the resistance against implementing comprehensive sex education programs in India.

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If we look at the scenario of sex-education in the USA, the overall condition regarding adolescence child health is considerably poor there. There is no strict and universal regulation regarding sex-education in the USA. According to the study by Duke, The Centre for Global Reproductive Health(2022), Only 39 states in the USA have made sex-education a mandate. What would be the content of the sex-educations, depends solely on the discretion of the particular state. As the study states,

The content of what is covered in sex-education varies widely from state to state, within states that do have government mandated sex-education, it is often left to individual districts to decide what to put into their sex-education curriculums [5]. The sex-education of so many young Americans is falling through the cracks. (Shah, 2022)

The issues of alternative sexuality, contraception, etc are not discussed with middle school students properly. As a result, the USA faces a lot of challenges regarding premarital pregnancy. In this regard, the issue of 'abstinence-only sex-education' becomes very relevant. The objective of the Absence-only-until-marriage(AOUM) program was to educate the youth of America regarding unwanted pregnancy and other sexually transmitted diseases. In order to spread this awareness, this program stated to not have sex till the time one gets married. But this program failed to achieve its goal because it deprived the youth of America of their basic rights. It was not scientifically planned. Knowledge can be best imparted through openness and experience, keeping something secret becomes detrimental to both the physical and the mental health of the young minds. This program did not become successful in lowering the rates of adolescence pregnancy and sexually transmitted disease like STI. As per a report by Guttmacher Institute,

Young people who express intentions to wait until marriage to have sex have the same rates of premarital sex, STIs, and anal and oral sex as their peers who do not take pledges. They are also less likely to use contraceptives, are at higher risk for HPV and have higher rates of nonmarital pregnancy compared with those who never pledged abstinence. (Guttmacher Institute, 2021)

The Guttmacher Institute report also states that the Absence-only-until-marriage(AOUM) program has been a failure to prevent teenage pregnancy as the complete inaccessibility to sex education and sexual activity till marriage has given a rise to rampant and unprotected sexual activities among young adolescents. The people who took the pledge of maintaining an abstinence from sexual activity till marriage have been more susceptible to STIs, getting pregnant due to lack of knowledge regarding contraception. As the report states,

Research shows that federal abstinence-only funding does not lower adolescent birth rates. In fact, the more that state policies emphasize abstinence-only programs, the higher the incidence of adolescent pregnancies and births....Young people who express intentions to wait until marriage to have sex have the same rates of premarital sex, STIs, and anal and oral sex as their peers who do not take pledges. They are also less likely to use contraceptives, are at higher risk for HPV and have higher rates of nonmarital pregnancy compared with those who never pledged abstinence. (Guttmacher Institute, 2021)

The issue of the type of sex education that needs to be provided in the USA remains unresolved as the USA records a higher rate of premarital pregnancy than other developed countries. As per a case study conducted among the people of the age group of 15–19 and 10–14 from various countries to find out the rate of pregnancy,

Among the 21 countries with complete statistics, the pregnancy rate among 15–19-year olds was the highest in the United States (57 pregnancies per 1000 females) and the lowest rate was in Switzerland(Sedgh et al.,2015)

From the above figures, it can be inferred that discussion on

comprehensive sex education should start at the kindergarten level itself; Netherlands has implemented introduction to sex education at the kindergarten level and the rate of teen pregnancy is five times lower than that of the USA. The countries where comprehensive and safe sex education is provided have lesser number of teen pregnancies and cases of unwanted pregnancies. It is the responsibility of the government, the parents, the educators to create a safe environment for children and young adults where they can confide in and express their concerns regarding the bodily changes they face, the undefined physical urges they feel need to be addressed properly in order to lower down the rate of infectious diseases, unwanted pregnancies and abortions,

It should be our specific goal to move American teens from Stages 1 or 2 (unaware or unengaged in the issues of pregnancy and STD prevention) to Stages 3–7 (informed decision-making) by providing them with knowledge, understanding, and sound decision-making skills. (Stanger-Hall and Hall, 2011)

While the governments of both countries showed failure in securing comprehensive sex education policy for its young population, the popular media plays a significant role in upholding the issue of middle school sex-education in a very sensitive way. The popular Netflix series *Sex Education* is a show which should be watched by teenagers and young adults all over the globe for its subtle interplay of abundant sexuality, the way it depicts young adults grappling with their sexual orientation, the intersectionality of gender, race and sexuality. The story revolves around a number of high school teenagers, the problems they face in coming to terms with their inadequacies, the complexity regarding their sexual orientation, the dilemma of embracing their native identity under the peer-pressure of being completely American.

Over four seasons, this show captures the myriad of sexualities like homosexuality, bi-sexuality, asexuality, pansexuality, the issue of masturbation, the trauma of a teenage girl Ammie, caused by an sexual assault in a public bus amounting to sexual frigidity. The fetish and taboo regarding alternative sexualities have been shattered and dealt with vivid reality and honesty. The show also ponders over the problem of loneliness among elders, like Otis's mother and Ola's father, how they come close to each other without bothering the fact that their children are dating each other. This is how one must rise beyond the conservations of our society.

If we look at the Indian context as far as the role of cinema or popular media in educating young adults regarding sex and sexuality is concerned, it is a mammoth task but surprisingly *Oh My God 2* has been a huge success in this field. The film fuses teenage problems of understanding sexuality with religious implications and establishes the importance and relevance of sex-education with the instances of the inclusive elements of Hinduism. It also shows the role of parents in understanding the anxiety, insecurity and social stigma that their kids face in society. It's a tale of a father's journey of fighting for his son against the odds of the society and also Indian Education System which is so oblivious to the needs of its students during puberty and adolescence.

2. Psychological implications of sex-education during middle-school or adolescence

Middle-School primarily addresses the age group of 12–15 during which children enter the crossroad of childhood and adolescence. Middle school marks a critical period in a child's development, characterized by the onset of puberty, hormonal changes, and burgeoning curiosity about sexuality. If the changes of their mind and body are not explained properly, it can harm the child both physically and mentally. Therefore, the significance of sex education in middle school lies in its potential to empower adolescents with essential knowledge and understanding about their bodies, reproductive health, relationships, and sexuality. Without proper guidance and education, adolescents may turn to unreliable sources such as peers, media, or the internet for

information, which can lead to misinformation, confusion, and risky behaviors.

Adolescence is a time when a person discovers their true self by categorizing their physical development; the students of this age group get bewildered by a lot of changes going on in their body that wreak havoc on their minds as well. In the case of the USA, the mandate on abstinence from sexual activities creates a sense of discrimination, alienation, guilt and shame around sexual activity. It is also incapable of explaining the impacts of sexual abuse to young people who face it in their household and elsewhere. As per the report by Guttmacher Institute,

abstinence-only programs are completely unprepared to meet the needs of the one in nine girls and one in 53 boys who have experienced sexual abuse or assault by an adult. (Guttmacher Institute, 2021)

Therefore, whenever the queries of the young adults do not get properly addressed by their parents and the schools, they resort to sources like random internet searches, pornographies and unauthorized websites. Young adults do not understand that pornography is a performance aimed at catering to the heteronormative culture of the world. Therefore it is often exaggerated and unrealistic. It is made not for the purpose of instructing people sexually but to titillate their suppressed desires. They also indulge in digital sex with known and unknown people for finding answers to the new experiences they are undergoing. Teenage people exchange their privacy with people hiding behind the anonymity of the web. As per the latest report of UNESCO,

When delivered well and combined with access to necessary sexual and reproductive health services, CSE empowers young people to make informed decisions about relationships and sexuality and navigate a world where gender-based violence, gender inequality, early and unintended pregnancies, HIV and other sexually transmitted infections still pose serious risks to their health and well-being. (UNESCO, 2023)

Here the role of both school and parents are crucial. Most of the time parents refrain from discussing sex and the information associated with sex with their children. Parent-child communication on these issues helps a lot in restraining the students from unprotected sex, HIV infections and STIs. The way parents talk to their children regarding sex determines the way their children would indulge in sexual activities. The children would develop self-efficacy, a control in themselves to have a choice of when to indulge in sexual activity and when to avoid it. However, most of the time, parents avoid communicating with their children regarding sex and the practices and behaviours associated with it leading to poor psycho-social behaviours and lack of agency regarding choosing what is right for them.

...while it is possible that parental communication about sex can be protective for youth, open sexual communication often does not take place. Instead, embarrassment, inaccurate knowledge, or low self-efficacy may prevent some parents from engaging their children in honest and supportive conversations about sexual behavior. (Widman et al., 2016)

Parent-child communication largely depends on demographic diversity, the gender of parents and the socio-economic background of the student. It is often found that children confide more in their mother than their father regarding their sexual issues. A mother helps her daughter in understanding that menstruation is a natural and healthy process for their health but very few parents educate their sons regarding menstruation as a part of women's body. As a result, boys develop a suppressed curiosity towards women's bodies which results in assaulting classmates and later on their partners.

The Netflix series *Sex Education* upholds this issue of parent-child communication very prominently. Here we find Jean, who is a sex therapist and the mother of the 16 year old Otis. Jean is always eager to

help out Otis with his sexual awkwardness, but Otis is never open for discussion regarding his sexual limitation with his mother. The society prescribed relationship of a child and mother manipulates Otis to not discuss his sexual problem with his mother. But the same Otis opens a clinic in the Moordale Secondary School to help out his peers in their confusions and anxieties regarding their sexual lives. Throughout the entire series, we find Jean counseling teenage people like Ammie, Maeve, Florence etc regarding their sexual confusions which helps them in coping up with their mental trauma stemmed out of sexual inadequacies. Jean guides the asexual character Florence by saying "sex doesn't make us whole, so how could you be broken"? (Allen, 2023). This throws light on the fact that sex is just a part of one's existence, if someone is unwilling to have it, it does not make the identity of that person incomplete. The characterisation of Jean Milburn harps on the importance of the normalization of parent-child communication regarding the latter's sexual life.

While talking about India, sex still remains a very tabooed subject, no parents and educators discuss the topics openly; even the teachers do not find appropriate vocabulary to address the concerns of their students due to lack of instruction materials. In India, menstruation is still stigmatized in both urban and rural areas; the young girls are not allowed to touch anything in the kitchen, they are not allowed to perform any religious practice during this time. In some rural areas, the girls are even isolated and kept in a separate place away from their main residence. All these superstitious practices spring from lack of proper knowledge regarding the biological importance of the menstrual cycle in a woman's body. During the 5–7 days of isolation, young girls go through both physical and mental trauma. They feel that they have been secluded probably because they have committed a sin. The Indian classrooms lack a proper discussion on menstruation, the importance of using sanitary napkins. Therefore it is high time that Comprehensive Sex Education gets implemented in the Indian context in order to make the young populace feel safe regarding their bodily changes and desires. As per a study by American India Foundation,

Comprehensive sexual education can teach about consent, healthy relationships and acceptance, fostering an environment of understanding... This also teaches the students about the correct age of having sexual intercourse, use of contraceptives, reducing the risks of unplanned teenage pregnancy and unsafe abortions. (Hendre, 2023)

Boys of teenage in India also have misconceptions regarding masturbation, most of the boys have the idea that masturbation is a sin and feel guilty of doing it. They are also confused regarding the 'proper' size of their penis. The parents and schools do not impart proper knowledge regarding their reproductive health and do not provide a comfortable environment so that the boys can confide their anxieties in them. A case study on the "Sexual and Reproductive Health in Adolescent School-Going Children of 8th, 9th, and 10th Standards" states,

Regarding masturbation, 89 % were not aware of the fact that it does not lead to weakness in future. Only 23 % of students were sure about the fact that masturbation is not a sin, while 56 % of them did not know the answer. Majority, ie, around 78 %, of the total students believed that being sexually attracted to a person of the same sex is unnatural. Only around 50 % of the students were aware that they have a right to say "no" to sex. (Deshmukh and Chaniana, 2020)

This issue is prominently addressed in *OMG 2* where we find a school boy named Vivek is made to believe by his peers that the size of his penis is not up to the mark for being a 'man'. He starts believing that he is not suitable for the girl he likes due to his 'inadequate' size of penis. To clear his doubts, he first questions his biology teacher whether his conception regarding the perfect size of penis is right or wrong. Instead of addressing the issue sensitively and delicately, the teacher reprimands Vivek, which leaves no other window open for Vivek. He falls prey to peer-bullying and resorts to harmful medications and rampant masturbation which ultimately becomes a threat to his life. Some of his friends

film him during masturbation and that video becomes viral among his neighbourhood and friend circle. What is so strange with this situation is that nobody blames the people who filmed him during his private act, but Vivek's character gets constantly assassinated by local people, his school friends, their parents and even by the police officers. This throws light on the taboo associated with a normal act like masturbation in a country like India. Instead of dealing with the issue with utmost sensitivity and maturity, the entire society starts maligning Vivek's conduct, isolates their family and pushes Vivek on the verge of committing suicide. The film throws light on another important issue of parent-child communication regarding sex education. Here in the film we see, Mr. Kanti Sharan, Vivek's father who is a devotee of Lord Shiva. Initially, Kanti himself was also not free from the social taboo associated with sex and masturbation, but the film shows how a messiah of Lord Shiva, played by Akshay Kumar guided him to overcome his limitations with the help of religiosity. When Vivek tries to end his life, Kanti realises his own failure as a father. Kanti files a court case against the negligence of the school where Vivek used to study and also sues himself because he holds himself as much responsible for his son's emotional breakdown as the society is. He fights with all his might, displaying the liberalism embedded in Hindu philosophy and mythology. Mr. Kanti is that father who is needed by every adolescent child, a father who will not judge his kid on the basis of what they have done, but will try to investigate and understand the probable reasons behind their child's act. Kanti in *OMG2* once again harps on the necessity of confiding in one's own parents. Scholars and researchers of Child Psychology all over the world have found Parent-Adolescent Sexual Communication as beneficial for a child's mental health and sexual behaviour.

There are both practical and theoretical reasons why parents may be agents of sexual socialization for young people. From a practical perspective, parents may play a critical role in conveying sexual information and may exert significant influence on adolescents' sexual attitudes, values, and risk-related beliefs. Parents may also provide a powerful model of open and honest communication about sexual health issues, which teens may emulate in their own sexual relationships. (Widman et al., 2016)

This concept of Parent-Adolescent Sexual Communication is a prominent and recurring theme in the Netflix Series *Sex Education*. Otis is a boy of 16–17 years who is capable of guiding people of any age group regarding their sexual health and other problems associated with their sex life, but he himself has certain issues associated with his own sexuality. His mother Jean is a sex-therapist who never cares for any personal boundary and always tries to guide her son Otis in terms of his sexual life, but Otis feels awkward in front of his mother's oversharing demeanor. Through Otis we also learn the fact that where too much secrecy regarding sex can be detrimental for a child's mental health, too much exposure to it can also make a child socially awkward and too much conscious. As James Poniewozik writes in his review in *New York Times*,

His adolescent anxiety about his body (he's not crazy about erections, either) is intensified by the constant T.M.I. factor of living with an oversharing parent in a house with erotic art on the walls and exotic implements in the drawers. (Poniewozik, 2019)

But living with his mother has gifted him with a skill to penetrate into other's minds and understand people psychologically. Through Jean's sessions with teenage students, the TV Series shows how important it is to listen to their problems to rescue them from psychological breakdown. One girl narrates to Jean how she is never attracted to anyone and feels that she is 'broken'. Jean vividly explains the concept of asexuality being very common and states "if sex doesn't make you whole, how can you be broken?". This line underlines the fact that sex is important in life but not indispensable, if one can live with it, another can even live without it. Another concerning issue which has been dealt with utmost sincerity and delicacy is sexual assault in public and the

trauma associated with it. Ammie is a character who has been shown as a very happy-go-lucky girl who is confused with her sexual desires. She had a boyfriend, had sex with him but never really enjoyed that. But later on in the show she faces utter trauma due to the fact that she was forcefully masturbated by a stranger while on the bus to school. This incident shatters her inner strength. Firstly she could not fathom what actually happened to her, but this incident leads her to suffer from Post Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD). This storyline takes a powerful stance to educate younger viewers regarding good and bad touch, what sexual assault is. In one morbid scene, we see a group of girls, who are searching for commonality among them finds that sexual assault is the only common thing they all have experienced. Thus *Sex Education* works as a potent medium to make the world sexually literate, to communicate to youth all over the globe that how common sexual assault is considering its viewership lies in million.

3. Popular Media's take on Inclusivity, Intersectionality and Diversity

The abstinence only program which is prevalent in the USA since the late 20th Century is essentially heteronormative and fosters LGBTQIA+ students as abnormal and deviant. This practice was further reiterated by the [Parental Rights in Education Bill which came out in 2022](#); the bill restricted sex-education in schools and negated the discussion of alternative sexuality in a certain grade level. The instruction regarding sexual orientation will be provided to higher grade students only if they are 'developmentally appropriate'.

In March of 2022, the passage of HB 1557 in the state of Florida, colloquially known as the "Don't Say Gay" bill, restricted discussions of sexual orientation and gender in the classrooms of students in kindergarten through third grade ([Parental Rights in Education Bill, 2022](#))

The erasure of the discussion regarding sexual orientation at the kindergarten level could be very detrimental towards a child's mental health. This bill instructs the educational bodies to identify a person only as male or female as per the genital they are born with. Thus this bill annihilates the binary of 'gender' and 'sex' and bans the choice of an individual to choose the gendered identity irrespective of their sex.

While the Federal Government of the USA is trying hard to eliminate alternative sexuality from the centre, not even providing space for the LGBTQIA+ community in the margins, the popular netflix series *Sex Education* portrays an Americanised school which consists of a lot of students who categorize themselves as sexually fluid. *Sex Education* is a series that delves deep into the psyche of each of the young minds it shows as characters. Be it a major character like Otis or Maeve or supporting characters like Eric, Adam, Ola and others. When it comes to inclusivity, the series serves as an easel where a beautiful rainbow has been painted and all sorts of sexualities have been dissected and celebrated. Not only the importance of sex education, it also demonstrates the intersectionality of race, color and sexuality. Here we have Eric, a Black male lead coming from a traditional African family who is unapologetically queer. He embodies immense positivity associated with homosexuality and queerness that becomes motivational for kids who are yet to come to terms with their true self. The way Eric cross-dresses, puts on make-up, wears jewelry without being afraid of getting judged is really inspirational. What makes Eric unique is his identity is never dominated by the fact that he is gay throughout the series. His identity as being gay is never represented as a stance to preach inclusivity by the makers. Through Eric the series gives the lesson to the young generation who shies away from accepting their hidden desires openly as Eric openly rejects Lily's proposal of having sex with her since he is gay. It is mainly due to the overpowering cis-heteronormative conduct of Adam's father who was the Principal of the Moordale Secondary School. Adam's father was always a heteronormative person, confined within his reservations. He always made Adam feel less. This idea of falling short of

his father's expectation takes a great toll on Adam's identity formation. We see Adam as someone who is never willing to accept his sexual orientation as a bi-sexual. He is confined within the closet and performs the way the society and his father want him to see. At the very beginning of the series, we see Adam faking his orgasm with his girlfriend Ammie. This once again upholds the fact that the overpowering discourse of heteronormativity does not allow non-binary existence to thrive. Eric gradually realizes that he and Adam are not meant to be together, because for being with Adam, Eric unknowingly falls prey to gendered performance. This realization hits Eric when he kisses and had sexual intimacy with a boy in Nigeria. Adam wanted to forget Eric's action and wanted to move on since Adam never questions the root cause of any incidence. Instead of enquiring Eric why he did so, Adam wanted to avoid the topic. Finally Eric calls off his relationship with Adam stating that he's "ready to fly" while Adam is only just "learning to walk". (Smith, 2023). Adam came out to be a confused and conflicted personality whose childhood trauma has created a sense of lower self-esteem. Towards the later seasons, we find Adam striking a bond with his father which finally helps to find his true self. While Eric advises Adam, he says: "You have to believe that you deserve good things. And Adam, you have to love yourself." (Smith, 2023). Through Eric and Adam's relationship, the series tries to send the message that how the homosexual relationships of young age get affected by external factors.

In the later part of the series, we see Eric as a religious person who visits church congregation, offers his service at the church regularly. In case of Eric only, we can draw a line of similarity between *Sex Education* and *OMG2*, since *OMG2* is deeply rooted in the religious way of clarifying and explaining sexuality and how it liberates us. Eric was first hesitant to get baptized because he thought his queer identity is not acceptable in Christianity.

Season 4 explores how myopic views of religion have contributed to the ostracization of communities and reinforced historical perceptions that sexual identity and religious identity cannot coexist. (Facey, 2023)

But with the progress of Season 4, Eric starts encountering a woman who embodies godliness or can be seen as an emissary of God, quite similar to the role of Akshay Kumar in *OMG 2*. Through the flashes of a black beggar in search of food, Eric understands that this is the call of God and he finally gets liberated when he embraces both his queerness and his religious identity of being a Christian.

The intersection of race and sexuality is also evident and celebrated through the household of Jackson. Jackson, a black sportsman who is reared by two mothers, one white and one black. The series never portrays them as something extraordinary, when Maeve, as Jackson's girlfriend first visits their household, it appeared to her as perfect as possible.

The only remark Maeve makes about Jackson's mothers is in a later episode in response to his admission that his "life is not so shiny" and she replies, "I thought your family was perfect. (Allen, 2023)

Sex Education leaves no stones unturned for presenting the LGBTQIA+ with all its diversity, apart from Eric, Adam, Rahim, Anwar we have two non-binary characters called Cal and Layla who are grappling very hard with their sexual identity. We see Cal's pain in understanding her bodily changes and her inability to synchronize her physical identity with her sexual identity. She carries an old tape recorder to record the bodily changes she is going through while she is on testosterone. Cal always feels that her existence is futile; that the world does not require people like her. When the new Principal of Moordale Secondary, Hope asks them to join the cue for girls, both Cal states "We don't fit into the description of boy or girl, so where are we supposed to go?" Hope dodges their question by stating that they will be instructed regarding female anatomy which might be helpful for both of them.

This refusal of non-binary identity and the principal's punitive response of forcing Cal and Layla to join a group they do not identify with, is a cis-heteronormative practice already documented in school-based sexuality education (Hobaica et al., 2019)

Through Cal, *Sex Education* penetrates into the layers of stigma associated with the trans community which is still persistent in the West. Through the conversations between Cal and Laila, Cal and Roman, we see the series is aiming at building a 'collective consciousness' of marginalized sexes. While *OMG2* deals heavily with the issue of masturbation as something natural for a teenage boy, *Sex Education* puts his foot one step ahead by dealing with female orgasm and masturbation as a medium of attaining sexual pleasure. Ammie in *Sex Education* is not happy with her boyfriend as she is unable to feel orgasm and pleasure through her sexual relationship with him. She finds out the way of self pleasure through masturbation and learns to accept the way her vagina is.

As such, Amy was represented as empowered to explore her own sexuality and subsequently portrayed legitimately and positively as a sexual subject. (Allen, 2023)

The final Season of *Sex Education* is all the more inclusive as it includes a lot of transgender characters, a prominent asexual character named 'O' and characters with special ability. The Final Season makes a departure from the conservative atmosphere of Moordale Secondary School to a utopian Cavendish School, a student-led campus for all. This season introduces three new queer characters Abbi, Roman and Aisha. Abbi and Roman are in love and their love and sexuality have been portrayed as plainly as any heterosexual relationship could be. The final season of *Sex Education* puts forward a number of trans individuals in a free utopic school environment where people are not ostracized or sensitized on the basis of their sexual desires, rather they are presented in a humane way.

Shows like *Sex Education* are allowing space to accurately represent trans stories. They provide a platform that's removed from political debate and prominent negative voices from outside the community. (Raines, 2023)

The final season also introduces a fierce asexual character named 'O' who snatches the position of being the sex therapist from Otis. O stands in contrast to the other asexual and vulnerable character Florence, introduced in the second season. This contrast of two asexual characters clears the notion that asexual characters are always docile, naive and confused. Here we have an asexual character who herself has no desire of sex, but advises the young people of Cavendish School regarding their sexual problems. The character emerges as a stereotype bully who is uncomfortable in laying her insecurities bare before her peers, but later on she expresses her reality of being an asexual in front of the whole Cavendish School. 'O' as a character is very instrumental in helping asexual people come to the forefront and forsake the feeling of being left out in the society. As Sarah Sharp writes in her blog,

O's outing storyline is a part of the series that felt particularly groundbreaking to me. Coming out, or sadly in some instances being outed, is an experience unique to the LGBTQIA+ community, and seeing this topic being discussed by an ace person validates that we have this experience too. (Sharp, 2023)

The final season throws light on the concept of ableism and disability. In this season, we find more of Isaac, a specially abled character who was envious of Maeve and Otis's burgeoning intimacy. Isaac was portrayed as someone envious of Otis's intellect and charm and suffering from inferiority complex due to the fact he cannot offer the same sexual fulfillment to Maeve due to his disability. However, Maeve was not at all concerned with Isaac's disability, in fact, they bonded on their common interest in art and culture. But in the final season, we find a new Isaac who has departed from his narrow-minded and self-centered

perspective. There is a glimpse of another disabled character Aisha who is partially deaf causing difficulty in her speech and she is also a queer. We see how her friends always try to provide room for her so that she can articulate what she wants to say. This is where *Sex Education* challenges the stereotype where disabled people are always put at the margin and ableism is always celebrated with its glory. The striking balance between ableism and disability is drawn through a powerful elevator scene, where Isaac and Ammie get stuck within an elevator and Isaac vents his frustration that how the school is not disability friendly, they cannot even fix an elevator. The representation of disabled character is not new but most of the time they are represented with an implicit sense of pity and sympathy, but *Sex Education* represents disability as opposite and balancing half of ableism.

The significance of the show extends beyond the screen. It contributes to the broader conversation about disability representation in media. It adds to the ongoing discourse on the subject further creating room for change. Through efforts for authentic portrayals of disabilities, the show has demonstrated the potential for shifts in perspective by reclaiming the narrative for inclusivity. (Gauri, 2023)

Thus *Sex Education* touches upon all sorts of tropes which are considered as 'sensitive' by the society and popular media. Audio-visual mediums like films, web series do not preach to the audience, rather they engage in conversations and see themselves in the characters on screen and experience the same issues. Netflix stands out from other OTT platforms in its rate of consumption by the Generation Z. Therefore, Netflix and its shows not only entertain its audience but hold a transformative power.

4. The social impact: real changes fostered by popular media

OMG 2 being an Indian commercial film can be seen as revolutionary since it not only questions the inadequacy of the Indian Education System to foster proper guidance to adolescents regarding sex and sexuality but also it highlights the liberalism of one of the ancient civilisations of the world. A country like India which worships the phallus or *linga* in the form of God must be accommodative towards the sexual reality of its majority of population, but sadly the film has to undergo 27 cuts and struggled a lot under the scrutiny of the Censor Board for getting a U/A certificate. The amalgamation of sex and religion was the main issue behind all these struggles, apparently the Censor Board thought this stance might be problematic and face backlash from common people and hurt their religious sentiment. Surprisingly, this particular blend of religion and sexuality made *OMG 2* a huge success.

The religious portrayal in the film resonated with the general public and touched their hearts. In retrospect, had the movie been shot in a metro city, most people would have brushed it off as being unrealistic or a problem of the "urbans". Moreover, the use of Hindi language, "Sanatan Dharma", and religious texts make this a more acceptable topic for the common man. (Patel, 2023)

If we talk about how these representations in popular media impact our society or how far we can implement sex-education in real life situations, we have to talk about an NGO named Bachpan Save The Innocence (aka BSTI). It is a non-profit organisation that was founded in 2020. Their moto is to prevent Child Sexual Abuse. They conduct a number of workshops, awareness programs all around India to educate children regarding such assaults and abuses. They help not only in getting these kind of cases reported which often do not get legally reported due to lack of information, but also offers redressal. Team BTIS sees *OMG 2* as a strong supporter of their objective. As they state,

Much like in *OMG 2* when the high priest's granddaughter gathers up courage post watching Vivek and shares about the sexual abuse by her own uncle, we have seen children open up to us post workshops and share their own CSA stories trustingly. We believe that with

timely knowledge and education to the children, we will be able to prepare and equip them better to deal with life. Ease of communication between the child and adult comes from a conducive environment, an environment that is child-friendly! (Patel, 2023)

A very encouraging effect of *OMG 2* is that an education society in Maharashtra has come up with the idea to include sex-education as a compulsory subject in their school curriculum. "The Ulhasnagar education society announced that it will be including the subject in school curriculums." (Kumar, 2023). In the presence of Amit Rai, the school organised a screening of the film in the presence of many state MLAs and school teachers and they received very positive feedback. This made all the struggles worthy as Amit Rai states,

The purpose behind making this film has been attained. I am so happy that the film is not just doing well commercially but our message has reached out to people at large and we are witnessing changes happening all around us. Nothing can be more gratifying than this. (Kumar, 2023)

Sex Education on the other hand touches all the aspects of sex and sexuality which sex education programs of the American schools failed to provide. It makes a huge social impact but introducing unexplored topics like vaginismus, chlamydia, the inability to have orgasm, the thin line between being queer and transgender, how is sex not a performance, how to not feel disabled before the dominating presence of ableism, how is mental health associated with someone's sex life, how important it is to have a communication with parents regarding someone's sexual confusions.

The series writers have inadvertently addressed many of the gaps in sexual knowledge left by school-based programmes and young people's criticisms of them. This is achieved by traversing an expansive array of sexual issues that speak directly to young people's lives and concerns. (Allen, 2023)

Sex Education as a series serves as an eye opener to the USA audience and demonstrates its characters as case studies whose problems come out to be extremely realistic. It validates the argument that the USA curriculum needs substantial changes in order to address sex education in a wider and inclusive manner. Many educators from the USA have acknowledged that *Sex Education* has imparted much more information than a conventional classroom can ever provide. The show has contributed to a more open discussion about sex education among students, parents, and educators. It addresses topics often considered taboo, encouraging more honest conversations about sexual health, consent, relationships, and LGBTQIA+ issues which are not dealt with proper care in conventional classrooms. In this regard, a survey by Madison Family Life Education (FLE) becomes very seminal,

According to a recent survey of 236 Madison students, 45.8 % agreed that the Madison Family Life Education (FLE) program has been informative and has prepared them to make informed decisions about sex. However, 74.6 % of students say that they have learned more about sexual topics outside of the classroom. (Levesque et al., 2020)

Even with the program's stated modifications, a lot of pupils still think the curriculum is inadequate. Although Derrick Rauen Zahn, The Department chair of Madison's Health and Physical Education department claims that in the last 10 years, these subjects have changed, some students feel that the curriculum still presents a more neutralised view of sexual issues and does not encourage discussion of certain genders or sexualities. For example, information on safe sex practices is given to students as they are learning about contraceptive techniques. After the release of *Sex Education*, the Departmental Chair has expressed his views on the probable changes that they want to include and have already included,

Changes are made annually,” Rauenzahn said. “We implement current events and ‘hot-button’ issues into our curriculum. There is an approval process through FCPS and the Virginia Department of Education (VDOE). In recent years, there has been a big emphasis on emotional and social issues. (Levesque et al., 2020)

The deepest impact that *Sex Education* has created is the liberation of suppressed souls. Students who always faced anxiety and confusion regarding their sexual life and sexuality have finally found validation through the show. Therefore inclusion of psychological dilemma and anxieties become all the more important:

One of the key elements of the series “Sex Education” is the display of unique relationships and the dilemmas that sprout from them. Otis must communicate to his first girlfriend, Ola, that he has never had sex and is initially very uncomfortable with the idea. Healthy communication between partners is also an important lesson within Fairfax County’s FLE program. (Levesque et al., 2020)

FLE program has limitations regarding the representation of the alternatives sexuality as their curriculum includes explanations only for LGBT and thus eradicates all other varieties of sexual orientations leading to its inadequacy as a curriculum.

According to the FCPS FLE curriculum, “Students with questions or concerns about their sexual orientation or gender identity will be advised to talk with a parent or other trusted adults such as members of clergy or health care providers. Emphasis will be placed on tolerance and nondiscrimination of all people.” By restricting open and honest conversations about sexuality and gender identity, FLE sends the message that this topic is not something acceptable to talk about. (Levesque et al., 2020)

Media being one of the strongest pillars of democracy has the power to bring positive change in any system. The show’s popularity has inspired advocacy groups and individuals to push for reforms in sex education policies in the USA. While implementing an immediate and major change in a structured form requires time, we cannot deny the fact that the series has greatly inspired educators and policymakers who are increasingly recognizing the gaps in traditional sex education and the importance of addressing a wider range of topics. The series has also led to increased visibility and utilization of support services, such as counseling and sexual health clinics, as it portrays seeking help as a positive and normal action.

Both *Sex Education* and *OMG2* as popular media can be immensely influential in breaking the jeopardy we have regarding sexual health in India and in the USA. American TV shows are unbelievably popular among its youth, the same is with Bollywood commercial films in India. A message aimed to the masses can best reach through popular media. In a tabooed country like India, *OMG2* can be seen as a stepping stone to a more progressive approach towards sex-education in middle schools. Parents must have understood the importance of being a friendly guide to their children from the film so that their children articulate the problem they go through due to the hormonal changes during adolescence. These stories teach the society how to bridge the gap between misinformation and formal education regarding sex and also address the unmet needs of the teenage population of both the countries.

Declaration of Competing Interest

I hereby declare that the manuscript has not been submitted or will

be submitted to other journals while the review process is on. I am also ensuring that I have read and understood the journal policies given on the website.

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